

Lab: Listening to What Wants to Happen

Objective

Explore embodied planning through mindfulness practice that reveals how the body anticipates, prepares for, and evaluates future action through the lens of breath, heartbeat, embodied being.

Prerequisites

- A quiet, comfortable space for 25 minutes
- Willingness to engage in mindfulness practice
- No prior experience required

Part 1: Arriving (5 minutes)

Sit comfortably and close your eyes. Take three slow breaths, letting each exhale be longer than the inhale. Bring your attention to the natural rhythm of your breathing without trying to change it.

Notice: your body is already planning. It is adjusting posture, regulating breath, and anticipating what comes next. Through breath, heartbeat, embodied being, attend to the body's forward-looking quality.

Write your response here

(What is your body preparing for right now? What future does it seem to anticipate?)

Part 2: Felt Futures (7 minutes)

Think of two possible activities. For each, let the body simulate the experience. Through breath, heartbeat, embodied being, notice the somatic response -- does the body lean toward one future or pull away?

Write your response here

(Describe the bodily response to each imagined future. Did the body have a preference? How did breath, heartbeat, embodied being inform this evaluation?)

Part 3: Emergent Action (7 minutes)

Rather than planning what to do next, ask the body: What wants to happen? Wait. Let a movement or action emerge without deliberation. Through breath, heartbeat, embodied being, trust the body's intelligence.

Write your response here

(What emerged? Was there a sense of rightness or flow? How does breath, heartbeat, embodied being support or challenge this kind of emergent planning?)

Part 4: Reflection (5 minutes)

Through breath, heartbeat, embodied being, reflect on the relationship between planning and presence.

Write your response here

(Can you plan without projecting anxiously into the future? How does embodied planning through breath, heartbeat, embodied being differ from intellectual planning?)

Reflection Table

Dimension	What I Noticed	Active Inference Connection
Initial awareness		Baseline generative model state
Embodied exploration		Prediction error through direct experience
Breath, heartbeat, embodied being lens		Course-specific perspective on planning
Integration		Updated understanding through bodily knowing

Discussion

Consider how breath, heartbeat, embodied being reveals aspects of planning that other perspectives might miss. In Active Inference, every perspective changes the precision weighting of different signals, revealing different dimensions of the same underlying process of free energy minimization.